

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

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Questions and Doubt

The writers of the psalms (called “psalmists”) are not afraid to ask questions and express their doubts. The number of questions in a psalm shows how intense the mood is or how important the issue is. The psalms with the most questions address key issues like when God seems to abandon his people and why evil people are successful (Psalm 13; Psalms 42–43; 74; 89; Psalm 73).

The writers of the psalms ask questions that help clarify problems in life. Some questions ask if the Lord is the true God (Psalm 94:9–10). Some ask why he seems to have abandoned godly people (77:7).

Other questions in the psalms emphasize:

- the success of evil people (10:13);
- the weakness of godly people (11:3);
- God’s choice of Zion (68:16);
- God’s power (114:5–6; 147:17);
- the foolishness of the nations (2:1); and
- the problem of injustice (82:2).

The psalmists question, examine, challenge, doubt, and sometimes despair over God’s seeming lack of concern.

The questions of the psalmists can lead to praise and worship: “Who can describe the mighty acts of the LORD or fully proclaim His praise?” (Psalm 106:2). For many questions, the answer brings praise to the Lord: “Whom have I in heaven but You? And on earth I desire no one besides You” (73:25; see also 89:8). Questions may also express amazement at God’s grace (8:4; 130:3; 144:3).

Asking good questions can be the beginning of a conversation with the Lord. This conversation can lead us along the path of wisdom and result in worship and praise.

Passages for Further Study

Psalms 2:1; 4:2; 6:3; 10:1; 11:3; 13:1–6; 22:1; 35:17; 42:1–11; 43:1–5; 44:23–24; 53:6; 60:9–10; 68:16; 73:1–74:23; 77:8–9; 79:5; 80:4, 12; 82:2; 83:2; 85:5–6; 88:14; 89:1–52; 90:11, 13; 94:3–4, 16, 20; 101:2; 108:10–11; 114:5–6; 119:82, 84; 137:4; 147:17